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TRACING POLITICIANS' CLASS BIAS

A quantitative evaluation of four explanations for unequal policy representation

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Abstract

Previous research has established unequal policy representation by social class, showing that political representatives are more aligned with and responsive to the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens than to those of working-class citizens. Despite having tested various potential mechanisms, the research field still lacks a clear understanding of what drives this unequal policy representation. This study simultaneously evaluates four possible explanations focused on the identity and supply of candidates for elected office, each of which could account for unequal representation: (1) the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives, (2) working-class representatives not substantively representing working-class citizens, (3) working-class representatives gradually representing working-class citizens less well over time in office, and (4) that candidates who substantively represent the working class are screened out of the electoral process. The aim of the study is to provide a roadmap for future research on which of the four explanations likely drive unequal policy representation and therefore require further investigation. I conduct a comparative quantitative analysis of repeated cross-sectional survey data from 30 European countries between 2005 and 2023. In this analysis, I (a) compare levels of unequal representation in terms of congruence between subgroups of citizens and parliamentary candidates, including both elected representatives and those who lost office, and (b) measure representatives' descriptive representation of working-class citizens. While the four explanations are found to have very limited explanatory power, the findings indicate that the pool of those who (can) become candidates is already skewed towards the views of middle- and upper-class citizens, suggesting that unequal representation arises earlier in the electoral process than commonly assumed.

AI-use description

I have used AI to (a) edit and polish to improve the language, specifically to help me remove grammatical errors in the thesis itself and (b) to assist with writing and troubleshooting code in Stata and R. The tools I have used for this are Google Gemini and Chat GPT. I have not used AI to generate any text for the thesis itself.

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1. Introduction

“In a political system where nearly every adult may vote but where knowledge, wealth, social position, access to officials, and other resources are unequally distributed, who actually governs?”

Dahl (1961, p. 1)

In this quote, Dahl calls into question whether formal political equality is really synonymous with actual political equality when resources that shape political influence are distributed unequally in society. This quote raises questions about whether the needs and wants of citizens in contemporary democracies are truly prioritized to the same degree by political decision-makers. Do politicians listen equally to people from different socioeconomic strata? Or do they adhere more to the preferences of the resource-rich? If so, what can explain this behaviour?

Previous research on political representation has established that there is unequal policy representation by social class, showing that elected representatives are more aligned with and responsive to the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens than to those of working-class citizens (e.g. Gilens, 2005; Bartels, 2008; Gilens & Page, 2014; Lupu & Warner, 2022a; Persson & Sundell, 2024). This finding potentially undermines a key purpose of representative democracy, which, as explained by Beyer and Hänni (2018), is for representatives to attend to the priorities and concerns of the citizens who have elected them. If elected officials do not accurately translate public opinion into policy, the need for them is called into question (p. S14). In addition, because a central feature of democracy itself is that those who are governed are considered equal (Dahl, 1971, p. 1; 1989, pp. 84-85), it also challenges the democratic ideal of political equality.

Accordingly, efforts have been made to understand the causes of unequal policy representation. While scholars have largely ascribed it to the massive influence of money in politics in contexts such as the U.S. (Gilens, 2012; Gilens & Page, 2020), unequal policy representation exists even in countries with political processes traditionally regarded as more egalitarian (Elkjær, 2020; Schakel, 2021; Persson, 2021; Elsässer, Hense & Schäfer, 2021; Mathisen, 2023). Despite having tested various potential mechanisms (e.g. Lupu & Warner,

2022b) the field still lacks a clear understanding of what drives unequal policy representation. Consequently, potential policy solutions to it also remain unclear.

In this thesis, I address this gap by answering the research question: *“When and why do politicians become less representative of working-class citizens?”*. I do this by simultaneously evaluating four possible explanations focused on the identity and supply of candidates for elected office, each of which could account for part of unequal policy representation: First, whether unequal policy representation is due to the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives (Carnes & Lupu, 2015). Second, whether it is because working-class representatives do not represent working-class citizens substantively (Persson, 2021). Third, whether it is caused by working-class representatives gradually representing the working class less well over time in office (Bailer et al., 2022). Fourth, whether it stems from candidates substantively representing the working class being screened out of the electoral process (Akter, Kerevel & Matthews, 2026; Rehmert, 2022). Previous research has largely only considered these explanations separately. However, realistically, they could each account for part of unequal representation. Therefore, it is necessary to consider them altogether and assign relative importance to each. The aim of this study is to provide a roadmap for future research on which of the four explanations likely drive unequal representation and therefore require further investigation.

To answer the research question, I conduct a comparative quantitative analysis of repeated cross-sectional survey data from 30 European countries between 2005 and 2023. I use nine matching survey questions to (1) compare subgroups of candidates, including both elected representatives and those who lost office, by the level of inequality they exhibit in their policy preference congruence with citizens, and (2) measure representatives’ descriptive representation of working-class citizens.

My findings show, first, that simulating perfect descriptive representation only slightly reduces unequal policy representation, suggesting that it is not primarily driven by the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives. Second, while working-class representatives also represent citizens unequally, they do so less than middle- and upper class representatives, suggesting overall unequal representation is not primarily driven by working-class representatives not representing working-class citizens substantively.

Third, I find that experienced and inexperienced working-class representatives exhibit virtually the same degree of inequality in their representation, meaning overall unequal policy representation cannot be explained by working-class representatives gradually representing the working class less well over time in office. Fourth, I find no evidence that candidates representing the working class substantively are screened out of the electoral process, as unequal representation is observed already among candidates who fail to win political office.

My findings suggest that politicians represent working-class citizens less well than middle- and upper class citizens in many European societies, regardless of their own social class background or experience in office. This unequal representation mainly arises because the pool of those who (can) become candidates is already skewed towards the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens, which, in turn, suggests that it may arise before politicians even become candidates. Considering that previous research has illustrated how politicians are influenced by party gatekeepers (Rehmert, 2022), donors (Gilens, 2012, ch. 8) and particularly politically active citizens (Broockman & Skovron, 2018), perhaps politicians need to appeal to such actors very early on in their careers in order to have the opportunity to even become candidates. If so, those who adapt their preferences according to the interests of such groups may become candidates, while those who fail to adapt never do.

In the sections that follow, I first outline previous research conducted within the field, along with this study's theoretical framework. Thereafter, I describe the methodological approach and design of this study. After that, I present and discuss the results. Finally, I conclude by summarizing the study's findings and providing implications for future research.

2. Literature review and theoretical framework

2.1 Definitions of concepts

As illustrated by Beyer and Hänni (2018), a core purpose of representative democracy is for citizens to be represented by elected officials who cater to their priorities and needs. Accordingly, if representatives do not share the public's views and transform them into policy, their function is undermined. Commonly, the extent to which representation is fulfilled is measured by two distinct concepts called *congruence* and *responsiveness* (p. S14; S39). The main difference between the two is time. Congruence typically refers to how well

citizens' and representatives' opinions, positions or priorities match at one point in time. Meanwhile, responsiveness involves at least two points in time, as it denotes the degree to which politicians' attitudes, behavior or decisions change in response to shifts in citizens' preferences. Though distinct from one another, both concepts are equally crucial for democracy, as they together determine "the full extent of successful representation of citizens' will" (pp. S15-S16). Consequently, discrepancies in either congruence or responsiveness are problematic, as this indicates citizens are not sufficiently represented.

2.2 Patterns of unequal representation

Over the past two and a half decades, a subfield within representation research has emerged that studies unequal policy representation by social class. Scholars have measured the preferences of groups of citizens (often sorted by income, occupation or education) and compared them to those of elected representatives and policy outcomes to determine which group of citizens politicians are most congruent with or responsive to (Burgoon et al., 2022, p. 298). This field has observed patterns of unequal representation that persist across countries, over time and across political issues. The initial evidence came from the United States. Bartels (2008) showed that the votes of U.S. senators matched the ideological placements of middle- and high-income citizens, while practically ignoring those of low-income citizens (p. 260). Gilens (2005) demonstrated that when citizens categorized by income want the same policy outcome, their views are reflected equally in policy output. However, when their views differ, outputs tend to reflect high-income citizens' views, and are "virtually unrelated" to what other citizens want (p. 789). Gilens and Page (2014) concluded that since the average American's political influence is practically insignificant, while that of the economic elite is so pronounced (pp. 571-575), it calls into question whether the United States is truly a democracy (pp. 576-577). Meanwhile, the literature suggests that the mechanism largely explaining unequal representation in the United States is the substantial influence of money in politics. Since American election campaigns are heavily dependent on private donations, the affluent are more capable than "ordinary" Americans to influence who gets elected. Not to mention the enormous sums the affluent also spend on lobbying in efforts to directly shape political outcomes (Gilens, 2012, ch. 8; Bartels, 2008, ch. 1).

However, more recently, scholars have found similar patterns of unequal policy representation beyond the United States, in countries with political processes far less dependent on private funds, and traditionally regarded as more egalitarian. For example,

Elsässer, Hense and Schäfer (2021) found that German lower-class citizens have no significant influence on policy change, while those with higher levels of education or higher-grade occupations do (pp. 1898-1899). Schakel (2021) examined responsiveness in the Netherlands and showed that median-income citizens' influence on policy diminishes when their opinions differ from those of high-income citizens (pp. 47-48). Mathisen (2023) observed a very similar pattern in Norway (pp. 753-756). Elkjær (2020) explored the Danish case and demonstrated that in terms of spending, the Danish government is solely responsive to citizens with high incomes (pp. 2228-2231). And in Sweden, Persson (2021) found that policies more often correspond to the opinions of the highly educated and men (p. 4).

Beyond studies of individual countries, some scholars have also conducted large-N comparative analyses. A good example is Persson and Sundell (2024), who compare citizens' preferences with policy outcomes from 30 European countries and almost 40 years (pp. 518-519). The authors conclude that since policy outputs are biased toward high-income citizens "again and again across issues, countries, and years to a degree that defies random probability", over time, it can build up to considerably affecting policy development (p. 523).

It is important to note, however, that the evidence for unequal policy representation is not unanimous. For example, skeptics have argued that it is merely a statistical illusion stemming from the coincidence that wealthier people have access to the same fiscal information as governments, which leads them to prefer the same countercyclical economic policies. Yet it remains unclear whether this explanation can account for unequal representation on noneconomic issues (Elkjær & Iversen, 2020, pp. 258-261). Nevertheless, taken together, the literature suggests that working-class citizens are insufficiently represented in nearly every context. But the question remains: Why is this the case?

2.3 Mechanism ambiguity

Evidently, unequal policy representation is observed even in countries where the potential for affluent citizens to convert their financial resources into political influence is very limited. Yet, there is no consensus of what drives unequal policy representation in these contexts. Among the very limited number of large-N comparative studies, few have attempted to map out "moderating conditions", that is, conditions that determine to what extent affluence is allowed to affect political power (Burgoon et al., 2022, p. 299). There are some indications that unequal representation is more prevalent in countries with higher income inequality and

corruption, and lower female representation (Lupu & Warner, 2022b, p. 75). Nevertheless, as already discussed, unequal policy representation is prevalent even in Scandinavia where such conditions are largely absent (Mathisen, 2023; Elkjær, 2020; Persson, 2021). Concurrently, other comparative studies have not found decisive evidence linking income inequality, nor linking other possible structural mechanisms like campaign regulation, union density, or voter turnout, to unequal policy representation (Persson & Sundell, 2024, p. 522). Resultingly, the reason why unequal representation keeps occurring across countries, over time and across political issues (Persson & Sundell, 2024, pp. 521) is not clearly established.

However, amid the mechanism ambiguity are four possible explanations focused on the identity and supply of candidates for elected office that, although commonly considered separately, may in fact each account for unequal representation, either in part or in full. Firstly, according to Explanation 1, working-class citizens are less well represented because of the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives in parliament. Secondly, per Explanation 2, they are less well represented because working-class representatives do not represent them substantively. Thirdly, following Explanation 3, working-class representatives substantively represent working-class citizens upon entering parliament, but then gradually do so less over time in office, leading to unequal policy representation. Fourthly, according to Explanation 4, the candidates who represent the working class substantively never even reach political office, because they are screened out of the electoral process. As there is currently no clarity within the field regarding which of these explanations most likely drive unequal policy representation, and because they are not necessarily mutually exclusive, it is necessary to consider them together and assign relative importance to each. Therefore, in the following subsections, I present each of these four possible explanations for unequal policy representation in further detail.

2.3.1 Explanation 1: The descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives

In the search for an explanation for unequal policy representation, scholars have also made efforts to examine so-called “mediating conditions”, that is, mechanisms that connect affluence to political power (Burgoon et al., 2022, p. 299). One frequently discussed mediating condition is unequal *descriptive representation*. According to Pitkin’s (1967) definition, descriptive representation refers to the extent to which the characteristics of elected representatives correspond to those they represent. In this sense, representation is

understood as “being something rather than doing something”. When representing, “the representative does not act for others; he ‘stands for’ them”. As such, the focus of descriptive representation is “less what the legislature does than how it is composed” (Pitkin, 1967, p. 61). This can be in terms of, for example, ethnicity, sex, age, religion, occupation or social class (Bailer et al., 2022, pp. 536-537). Carnes and Lupu (2023) argue that in most contexts, politicians are significantly more well off than the people they govern. Citizens from the working class are descriptively underrepresented to a considerable extent practically everywhere (p. 256). For instance, labor forces in OECD countries typically consist of a 56-58% share of people who hold what the authors categorize as working-class jobs. In contrast, only 3-5% of parliamentarians in OECD countries held working-class jobs upon entering politics (pp. 257-258). Similar patterns have been found beyond the OECD, for example across Latin America (Carnes & Lupu, 2015, p. 7). This suggests that parliamentarians almost exclusively come from economically advantaged backgrounds, while the majority of citizens do not (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, pp. 256-258). Consequently, there is descriptive misrepresentation (Bailer et al., 2022, pp. 536-537) by social class in most contexts.

One problem with unequal descriptive representation is the possibility that it translates into unequal substantive representation. Previous research indicates that representatives from economically advantaged backgrounds generally have more rightist views on economic policy (e.g. Hemingway, 2022, p. 85; Courtney, 2015, p. 195). They tend to think more like economically advantaged citizens, who care less about inequality and oppose redistribution. Although much of the policymaking process leaves limited room for representatives to shape policy according to their personal preferences (e.g. because they are constrained by the party whip) they have more freedom to do so during the so-called “agenda-setting” or pre-voting stage of policymaking. Throughout the agenda-setting stage, representatives themselves have the opportunity to propose new bills, to sponsor bills during their introduction onto the legislative agenda of parliament, and to debate bills introduced by other representatives, before formal roll-call voting takes place (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, pp. 258-260). Since the agenda-setting stage is where “problems are identified, solutions are crafted, and the legislative agenda is set” (Carnes & Lupu, 2015, p. 14), it is arguably “no less consequential” for policy outcomes than actual roll-call voting (Carnes & Lupu, 2015, p. 11).

Meanwhile, research indicates that representatives from working-class backgrounds sponsor bills that are more progressive on issues related to labor, the economy, and redistribution (Micozzi, 2018, p. 95, 104). It also suggests they favor redistribution to a greater extent in their speeches in parliament (O’Grady, 2019, p. 557). Put differently, representatives from working-class backgrounds seem to promote policies that working-class citizens prefer. However, since they only make up about five percent of parliaments (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, 257-259), the availability of representatives who promote the interests of working-class citizens during pre-voting in parliament is very limited. And in the words of Carnes and Lupu (2015), “if no legislator is willing to propose a given policy, it cannot be considered or debated, let alone enacted” (p. 11). Taken together, descriptive representation drives unequal policy representation in theory, because it constrains the number of representatives promoting policy that mirrors the preferences of working-class citizens. Therefore, Carnes & Lupu (2015) posit that if we were just able to balance parliaments along economic lines, representatives’ class background would contribute less to unequal representation (p. 14).

However, although research indicates that larger shares of parliamentarians from working-class backgrounds produce more leftist policy (Alexiadou, 2022; Borwein, 2021), a concrete link between unequal descriptive representation by social class and unequal responsiveness has so far not been established (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, p. 265). The constraint on representatives’ personal preferences during voting makes it practically impossible for responsiveness studies to distinguish any independent effect of their class background on policy output (Carnes & Lupu, 2015, p. 2). Nonetheless, by shifting the analytical focus to preference congruence between representatives and citizens, rather than analyzing actual policy outcomes, it is possible to observe the influence of representatives’ descriptive class background on unequal representation without party discipline directly constraining the analysis. In sum, testing whether perfect descriptive representation by social class in parliament translates into equal policy representation is necessary to determine whether unequal policy representation is driven by the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives.

2.3.2 Explanation 2: Working-class representatives do not represent working-class citizens substantively

It is also possible that unequal descriptive representation cannot explain unequal substantive representation, because working-class representatives do not represent working-class citizens

substantively. For example, Persson (2021) shows that the preferences of disadvantaged representatives and disadvantaged citizens are less aligned than those of advantaged representatives and advantaged citizens, while actual policy output is more congruent with the latter two. Persson therefore argues that policy output is skewed toward advantaged citizens because disadvantaged representatives, for reasons unknown, do not represent their social class sufficiently. As such, even if parliaments were perfectly balanced by social class, advantaged citizens would still be better represented than disadvantaged citizens (pp. 4-6). As far as I know, Persson's study is the only of its kind so far. Although its data covers multiple elections, it is limited to the Swedish case, meaning there is a need to investigate whether similar patterns exist in other countries.

One reason working-class representatives may not substantively represent working-class citizens is that they may overestimate the importance of the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens, possibly due to low levels of political participation among working-class citizens. Broockman and Skovron (2018) found that American politicians consistently overestimate the conservatism of citizens (p. 543). They argue that this happens because conservative Americans are far more politically engaged than liberals. Consequently, politicians become more informed about the preferences of conservative citizens, which they come to believe are more important (pp. 543-545). Scholars have recently found similar patterns of misperception outside of the American context (e.g. Pilet et al., 2023; Soontjens & Persson, 2024). Reasonably, Broockman & Skovron's (2018) logic, that politicians listen more to citizens who participate more, and represent these citizens better than citizens who participate less (pp. 543-545), directly applies to unequal policy representation by social class. This is because research suggests that middle- and upper-class citizens generally participate more in politics than working-class citizens (Dalton, 2017, pp. 44-51; Schlozman, Verba & Brady, 2012, pp. 122-126; Marien, Hooghe & Quintelier, 2010, pp. 205-206), meaning that representatives, just like they are skewed towards conservatives, may also be biased toward middle- and upper-class citizens.

While previous research has speculated that unequal political participation may drive unequal responsiveness (e.g. Elsässer, Hense and Schäfer, 2021, p. 1892), most research on this subject is forced to revert to analyzing differences in turnout. Schlozman, Verba and Brady (2012), argue that empirically isolating the effect of other forms of political participation on politicians' behavior amid the constant barrage of information they receive is very difficult

(p. 140). That said, a few studies on the effects of political participation on unequal representation have been conducted, and have produced mixed results. For example, Bartels (2008) finds that differences in political participation by social class has profoundly limited explanatory power (p. 279), and Schakel (2021) finds that social-class differences in voting can only explain a small portion of unequal representation (p. 50).

Meanwhile, other studies indicate that unequal representation cannot be explained by the participation-misperception mechanism outlined above, but rather by politicians simply not expecting to be held accountable by working-class citizens. Soontjes and Persson (2024) surveyed local Swedish and Belgian politicians to examine whether unequal representation stems from representatives lacking accurate information about constituents' preferences, or by a lack of electoral incentives, that is, whether they expect to be held less accountable by low-income citizens (p. 815). The study found that representatives expect to be held accountable much less by low-income citizens than by high-income citizens, reducing their incentive to represent them. However, this was not due to insufficient information about low-income citizens' preferences, as representatives estimated the preferences of low- and high-income citizens with equal accuracy (pp. 827-829).

In sum, the literature suggests that working-class representatives may not represent working-class citizens substantively, leading to unequal policy representation. This may be caused by either (1) that working-class citizens participate less politically, which leads politicians to become less exposed to their preferences and therefore mistakenly undervalue them. Or (2) that politicians simply feel less accountable to working-class citizens.

2.3.3 Explanation 3: Working-class representatives gradually represent working-class citizens less well over time in office

Another explanation for unequal policy representation is that working-class representatives initially represent the working class substantively upon entering parliament, but that they gradually do so less over time in office. One reason for this may be that working-class representatives' attitudes on issues important to the working class shift because they enter a new social class upon entering parliament. For many working-class candidates, becoming a representative arguably constitutes a form of upward class mobility. For example, as demonstrated by Kotakorpi, Poutvaara, and Terviö (2017), being elected to national office usually brings a substantial increase in income for politicians (pp. 425-426). And, again, as

parliaments are almost exclusively filled with representatives from affluent, white-collar backgrounds (Carnes and Lupu, 2023, p. 256), working-class candidates who get elected arguably enter a new social class position, located among the political and economic elite.

Several studies describe how upward class mobility may affect people's economic policy preferences, especially those related to inequality and redistribution (Jaime-Castillo & Marqués-Perales, 2019; Ares, 2020; Wilson et al., 2022). It has been argued that people moving into a new social class experience a process of re-socialization in which their political beliefs gradually shift away from their origin class and closer to their destination class (Jaime-Castillo & Marqués-Perales, 2019, pp. 140-141).

Such a shift may be driven by several factors. One is material self-interest. People form preferences on redistribution that reflect their own material well-being (Jaime-Castillo & Marqués-Perales, 2019, pp. 140-141). Another factor is that meritocratic attitudes, which are often synonymous with conservative stances on, for example, redistribution, help legitimize upward movement as earned, which is psychologically important for upwardly mobile people attempting to make sense of their new class position (Wilson, 2022, pp. 1057-1058). A further contributing factor may be group pressure. People simply want to be accepted by their destination-class peers (Jaime-Castillo & Marqués-Perales, 2019, pp. 140-141). As such, when there is ambiguity about which social class one belongs to, people prefer to embrace the class identity which has higher social status. Consequently, when upwardly mobile working-class people enter their destination class, they may sacrifice their social ties to the working class as they form new social connections in their destination class (Weakliem, 1992, p. 154).

The overall outcome of this socialization process is that upwardly mobile people come to embrace the values and norms of their destination class (Wilson, 2022, pp. 1057-1058). For people from the working class, this may manifest in lower support for economic policy like state intervention and redistribution (Ares, 2020, p. 1219). That said, because upwardly mobile people still maintain some social contact with their origin class after having entered their destination class, the shift in attitudes is not instant. It evolves gradually over time as the upwardly mobile become older and spend more time in their destination class (Ares, 2020, pp. 1218-1219; Jaime-Castillo & Marqués-Perales, 2019, pp. 140-141).

Another reason why working-class representatives may gradually represent working-class citizens less well over time in office is that they do so to advance their parliamentary careers. Bailer et al. (2022) conducted a study of disadvantaged German representatives' parliamentary interpellations over a fifteen-year period (pp. 541-542). The authors argue that disadvantaged representatives utilize their disadvantaged background at the start of their parliamentary career by submitting many interpellations on issues important to disadvantaged citizens. Because other representatives view them as experts on such issues, they receive a credibility boost from doing this. However, over time, disadvantaged representatives become more effective at legislating and gain their colleagues' consent to dedicate more attention to other, broader policy areas, which is important for them, because appealing to a wider voter base is necessary to climb the party ladder. As such, they begin dedicating less attention to issues important to the disadvantaged (p. 538-540).

Taken together, it is possible that unequal representation is explained by working-class representatives gradually representing working-class citizens less well over time in office, possibly due to changes in economic preferences driven by upward class mobility upon entering parliament and a reduced prioritization of working-class interests as they advance their parliamentary careers. This may explain why, as suggested by Persson (2021), it seems like working-class representatives undergo a “social class journey” that makes them “atypical of their class” (p. 5).

2.3.4 Explanation 4: The candidates who represent the working class substantively are screened out of the electoral process

Another explanation for unequal policy representation is that candidates who represent the working class substantively are screened out of the electoral process. According to Carnes & Lupu (2023), it is unclear why parliaments around the world fundamentally lack working-class representatives (p. 265). Although individual studies attribute this to the fact that turnout is lower among working-class citizens (Wüest & Pontusson, 2022, pp. 411), there seems to be consensus within the field that voter bias toward affluent, white-collar candidates is not the explanation. Voters likely even desire to have more representatives come from working-class backgrounds (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, pp. 262-263). If the voters are not directly responsible for keeping working-class candidates out of parliament, the explanation is possibly located earlier in the electoral process.

A possible explanation is that working-class candidates are screened out of the electoral process by political parties. Akter, Kerevel & Matthews (2026) go as far as theorizing that parties effectively discriminate against working-class candidates. For example, party selectorates may prefer candidates with high levels of legislative experience, which working-class candidates typically lack since they hold office in far fewer numbers. Or, whether consciously or not, selectorates may simply prefer candidates with the same upper-class background they themselves commonly have (p. 2). Regardless, Akter, Kerevel & Matthews, who examine candidate placement on German and Moldovan party lists, find that working-class candidates are routinely placed lower on such lists (p. 4).

Furthermore, Rehmert (2022) argues that for parties, nominating candidates is essentially a principal-agent problem. As nominations entail the delegation of power from parties (principals) to candidates (agents), conflicts of interest may arise in which parties risk losing control. To avoid losing agency, parties conduct screening measures before nominating a candidate. Rehmert describes that parties generally want candidates who not only are active and ambitious lawmakers, but who clearly fall in line with the party's agenda and are loyal to the party leadership. Therefore, it is of utmost importance to screen out mismatches who could potentially hurt electoral performance. Candidates seeking nomination are aware of this and are thus incentivized to demonstrate that they are loyal to their party and its agenda in order to secure nomination. As candidates' exhibits of obedience are performative to varying extent, party selectors must screen them by two types of characteristics which Rehmert refers to as cues of "*valence*" and cues of "*homophily*". Valence denotes the meritocratic quality of a candidate, such as their perceived legislative competence, campaign experience or career record with the party. Accordingly, in terms of valence, selectors naturally prefer incumbents over other candidates, as they are meritocratically superior. Homophily entails that people connect more effortlessly with those who hold similar views and are descriptively alike. Hence, selectors prefer candidates who are and think like themselves (pp. 1153-1155). In short, Rehmert conducted a survey experiment in which German party selectors were tasked with selecting between different candidates (p. 1157) and the results indicated that candidates are selected both on grounds of valence and homophily (pp. 1164-1166).

Given that parliaments lack representatives substantively representing the working-class adequately (Persson, 2021, pp. 5-6), candidates who do are at a meritocratic disadvantage because they lack prior parliamentary experience. Consequently, party selectors, who prefer

incumbent candidates, may screen them out. Additionally, given Rehmert's (2022) discussion about selectors' pivotal political influence (p. 1149), they arguably belong to the political elite which, again, Persson (2021) has shown is not congruent with disadvantaged citizens (p. 5). Therefore, candidates who represent the working class substantively may be screened out also because they neither are similar to nor think similarly to party selectorates. If parties screen out candidates substantively representing the working class, either for meritocratic reasons or, whether consciously or not, based on pure "likeability", it may in turn explain why unequal policy representation happens in spite of perfect descriptive representation.

2.4 Next: Testing which explanations are most plausible

As mentioned earlier, the four possible explanations for unequal policy representation outlined here are largely not mutually exclusive and could each account for unequal representation, either in part or in full. For example, it could be the case that working-class representatives are numerically outnumbered in parliament, leading them, as a collective, to underrepresent the working class (as in Explanation 1). Simultaneously, working-class representatives themselves may not substantively represent the working class (as in Explanation 2), so that an already unequal parliament becomes even less representative. This underrepresentation may then increase over time as working-class representatives advance their careers and socialize in parliament (as in Explanation 3), while candidates who would have substantively represented working-class interests had they been elected are screened out of the electoral process (as in Explanation 4). Again, as the field lacks an understanding of which of these explanations most likely drive unequal representation, this study evaluates them altogether and assigns relative importance to each, to provide greater clarity for future research on which explanations to investigate further. If none of these explanations account for unequal policy representation, it would suggest that the mechanism is located earlier in the electoral process, at the candidate stage or possibly even before people become candidates. This is because, if not even electoral screening (Explanation 4) can explain unequal policy representation, it would indicate that unequal representation must also exist in the pool of candidates who never even entered political office.

3. Methodology

3.1 Design

To answer the research question “When and why do politicians become less representative of working-class citizens?” I conduct a comparative quantitative analysis of survey data that spans across countries and years to (1) compare levels of unequal representation in terms of congruence in political preferences between subgroups of citizens and parliamentary candidates, including both elected representatives and those who lost office, and (2) measure representatives’ descriptive representation of working-class citizens. I focus on comparing unequal representation in terms of preference congruence mainly for two reasons. First, it only requires comparing attitudes at one point in time (see subsection 2.1), which is more manageable given the scope of this thesis. Second, by strictly comparing attitudes based on survey responses, rather than including, for example, actual policy output as many responsiveness studies do, it is possible to capture politicians’ true preferences in a context where they are not constrained by, for instance, party discipline (see subsection 2.3.1). The focus on candidates, rather than solely elected representatives, is mainly motivated by the need to test Explanation 4, which requires me to examine whether candidates outside parliament are more equal in their representation than those in parliament. I begin this section by presenting my approach for case selection. I then describe my material. After that, I operationalize key concepts and describe my analytical strategy including robustness checks. Finally, I briefly describe the limitations of my study and discuss ethical considerations.

3.2 Case selection

There are two main prerequisites for quantitatively comparing congruence levels between different groups of candidates and citizens using survey data. The first one is that there must be matching survey questions on which both candidates and citizens have expressed their political preferences. The second one is that survey items asking respondents’ about their descriptive characteristics need to be available in order to distinguish between them. Consequently, case selection for this study is fairly straightforward: I first examine all major cross-country candidate- and citizen surveys to identify matching question items. All cases for which comparable question items are found between a candidate survey and a citizen survey are kept, and all cases for which no match is found are excluded. After this initial

scan, I check the surveys for items that describe respondents' characteristics. In the candidate surveys, I look for items indicating (a) whether the candidate was elected in the specified election, (b) whether they have previous parliamentary experience, and (c) their social class. In the citizen surveys, I mainly check for items about respondents' social class. All cases which include this information are kept for the analysis while those that lack it are excluded. After this I handle missing data. I exclude all observations containing missing values on key variables. In addition, all observations that contain non-responses, whether because a question was not asked during surveying, or because a respondent refused to answer, are recoded to missing and excluded from the analysis.¹

3.3 Material

I have constructed my own dataset using data from four different cross-country surveys: The *Comparative Candidates Survey* (CCS), the *European Election Candidate Study* (EECS), the *European Social Survey* (ESS), and the *European Election Studies* (EES).

First of all, I have derived data on the preferences- and characteristics of candidates mainly from the Comparative Candidates Survey. The CCS is a cross-national research project that surveys candidates for national legislatures. Because it has been conducted in connection with national parliamentary elections since 2005, the CCS has an extensive coverage, spanning three waves up to 2024. Altogether, it covers 75 elections in 28 countries, most of them European (CCS, 2026). I use all three waves of the CCS. After handling missing data, my CCS sample covers 51 national elections in 23 countries over the period 2005-2023.²

Secondly, I also gather candidate data from the European Election Candidate Study. The EECS is the only cross-national candidate survey apart from the CCS that I am aware of. However, unlike the CCS, it surveys candidates for the European Parliament (Giebler, Haus & Weßels, 2010, p. 3), which at first glance may come across as troublesome. For instance, Costello, Thomassen, and Rosema (2012) demonstrate that the EU-level congruence dynamic between candidates and citizens is more complicated than at the national level. Precisely, the EP forces national parties to aggregate into party groups and compromise their true policy

¹ See Appendix A for a data processing summary.

² See Appendix B for a complete overview of the countries and years covered by the data. I exclude a substantial amount of CCS observations from my sample. This is mainly due to the lack of information on candidates' parliamentary experience or whether they were elected, which renders many CCS observations irrelevant to include in my analysis.

positions, making EP-candidates less congruent with citizens than national politicians (pp. 1243–1246). However, I do not consider this problematic for my analysis, because there are no indications that the unequal representation of working-class citizens is different between the national and EU level. Therefore, I consider sampling the EECS to be acceptable, as long as I keep the above in mind during robustness checks. Nevertheless, because of the availability of matching question items, my EECS sample only covers the 2009 EP election. However, although the sample's temporal coverage is very limited, its geographical scope is fairly large - it covers all 27 EU member states (Giebler, Haus & Weißels, 2010, p. 3).

Thirdly, I measure the preferences and characteristics of citizens mainly using data derived from the European Social Survey. The ESS is a cross-national survey that has been conducted every two years since 2001 in 39 countries in total, most of them European (ESS, 2024, p. 4). I use the ESS because it is virtually the only survey that asks citizens the same questions regarding policy preferences as the CCS asks candidates across the same countries and election years. To temporally align my ESS sample with my CCS sample, I use rounds 2 through 11 of the ESS. As such, the ESS data in my sample covers the period 2004-2023.

Fourthly, the only other cross-national citizen survey that includes survey items matching the candidate surveys is the European Election Studies. The EES is a cross-national research project which, similar to the EECS, is conducted in EU member states in connection with elections to the European Parliament. Although it has been conducted with every EP election since 1979 (Gesis, n.d.), there are matching survey items only in the 2009 round of the survey. This means that my EES sample covers all EU member states in a single year, identical to my EECS sample.

In sum, after case selection and handling missing data, the analytical sample is fairly large and covers 60 elections, 30 countries and 19 years. Using data with a large geographical and temporal coverage is desirable as it increases the generalizability of my study (Esaiasson et al., 2017, pp. 28-29).

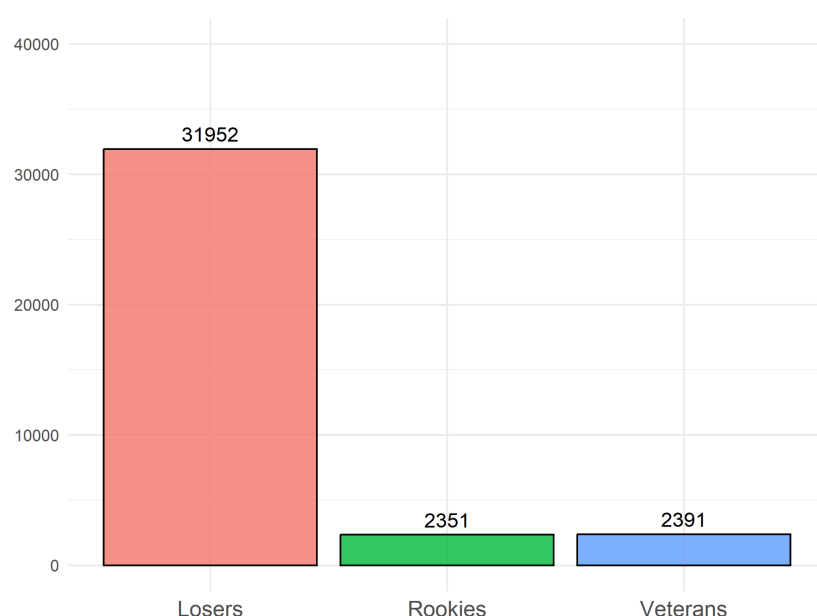
3.4 Operationalization

First, I use various CCS and EECS survey items that measure candidates electoral success and parliamentary experience to aggregate them into election *winners* and *losers*. I also subdivide the winners into parliamentary *rookies* and *veterans*. Rookies are those who are

first-time election winners. Veterans are those who have previous parliamentary experience.³ The distribution of losers, rookies and veterans in the analytical sample is shown in Figure 1.

Figure 1

Total number of losers, rookies, and veterans in the analytical sample.



Next, I use education level as a proxy for both citizens' and candidates' social class background. In the research field, income level, occupation type and education level are all considered standard indicators of social class. As there is no definite answer to which one is best (Carnes & Lupu, 2023, pp. 254-255) some scholars even use all three metrics together (e.g. Elsässer, Hense & Schäfer, 2021, pp. 1895-1896). However, using only education level in my analysis is motivated by three reasons. Firstly, the income and occupation items that are available across the surveys are either unevenly distributed across countries and years or, at least in many cases, measured using different scales across countries. This makes it difficult to accurately compare respondents across cases. Doing so would require extensive recoding beyond the scope of this study. Secondly, although the concept of social class is relative, it is reasonable to compare candidates and citizens using the same measure. While both citizen surveys include items on education, income, and occupation, the candidate surveys only include education and occupation items. However, as the occupation items are not comparable across surveys, education level is the only feasible indicator of social class available across all data sources. Thirdly, it is reasonable to assume that education generally

³ See Appendix C for an overview of which CCS and EECS items were used to aggregate candidates by electoral and parliamentary success.

predicts both future occupation and income, making it a useful proxy for social class, even in the absence of information on income and occupation.

Accordingly, I operationalize the concept of social class for both citizens and candidates by using their level of education. I do this by categorizing respondents as either *low-educated* or *highly educated*. In accordance with international standards, the highly educated category includes respondents who hold a university bachelor's degree or above, while the low-educated category includes those with less education. That said, I recognize that not all education levels below a bachelor's degree are generally considered "low". I merely use the labels "low" and "high" as a shorthand. Nevertheless, the categorization is motivated by three reasons. First, previous research has shown that having a university degree is especially important for exerting political influence (Schakel & van der Pas, 2021, p. 428). It is also described almost as a prerequisite for holding political office (Bovens & Wille, 2017, p. 120). Second, I need to harmonize different education level measures across surveys into a common format.⁴ Third, using only two categories increases statistical power.

Figure 2 visualizes the distribution of candidates by education level in my analytical sample. Visibly, only about 32% of candidates are low-educated. Meanwhile, Figure 3 shows the corresponding distribution for citizens, in which the low-educated account for about 74%. However, Figure 2 should not be interpreted as a highly precise description of the real-world candidate population, because sample restrictions and handling missing data has severely reduced the analytical sample.⁵ In contrast, Figure 3 is arguably highly representative of the real-world citizen population, as a cross-reference with the original citizen sample shows that about 71% of citizens were low-educated.⁶ Nevertheless, the distributions illustrated in Figure 2 and Figure 3 largely resemble well-known patterns of unequal descriptive representation by education (e.g. Bovens & Wille, 2017), in which there are relatively few low-educated politicians compared to their citizen share.

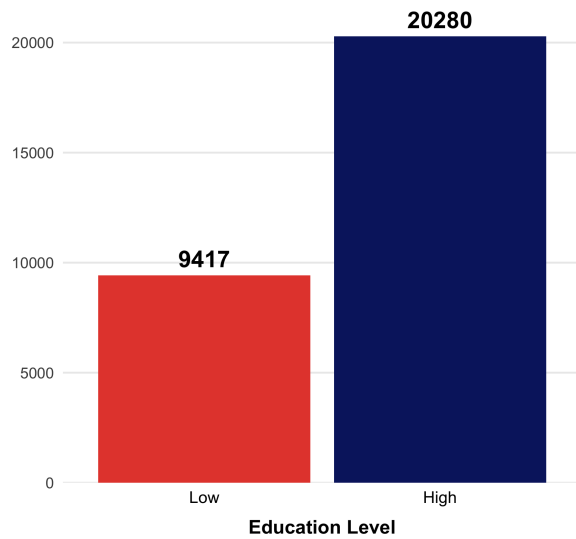
⁴ See Appendix D for an overview of which survey items were used to aggregate respondents by education level.

⁵ The original candidate sample lacked education level data for roughly 36% of candidates. I have excluded further observations due to missing data in key variables. Consequently, the analytical sample only includes about 52% of the candidates from the original sample.

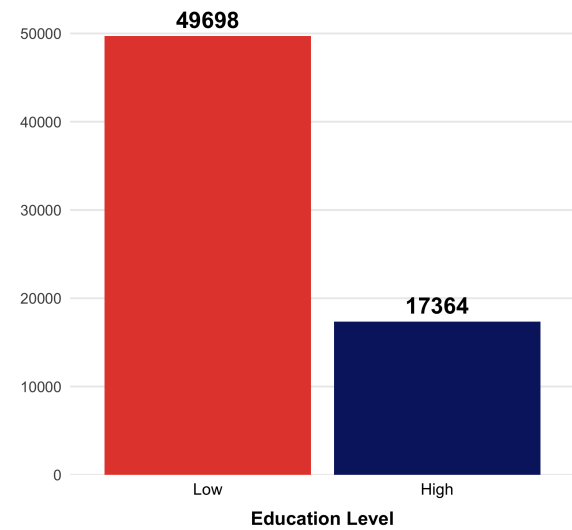
⁶ The process of matching candidate and citizen survey responses by country and year reduces the citizen sample by roughly 90% due to missing data. The cross-reference was made with the original citizen sample in which less than 1% of observations lacked education level data.

Figure 2

Candidate education level shares.

**Figure 3**

Citizen education level shares.



Then, I operationalize descriptive representation in accordance with standard approaches in the field (e.g., Gerring, Jerzak, & Öncel, 2024, pp. 787-790) as the difference between the share of candidates and the share of citizens from a given social class background. Using respondents' education level, I calculate the percentage share of candidates and citizens from each social class group in each country-year.

Next, Candidates' and Citizens' *policy positions* are operationalized using nine matching question items that I have found across the four surveys. There are both economy-focused items like "The government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels" and more socially or culturally oriented items like "Women should be free to decide on matters of abortion".⁷ Respondents indicate the extent to which they agree or disagree with a question or statement on a scale, usually between 1 to 5 or 0 to 10. To ensure comparability across issues, I first harmonize all intervals to a 0-to-1 normalized scale. Then, in line with common practice, I align the direction of scales so that the value 0 always indicates the most conservative position and 1 always indicates the most liberal position. To exemplify, this means that for the question item "Same-sex marriages should be prohibited by law", those who strongly agree are coded 0, agree 0.25, neutral 0.5, disagree 0.75 and strongly disagree 1. Table 1 reports the mean policy position, standard deviation and number of observations for candidates and citizens across the 9 issues included in the analytical sample.

⁷ Appendix E shows an overview of which original survey items are included in the analysis.

Table 1

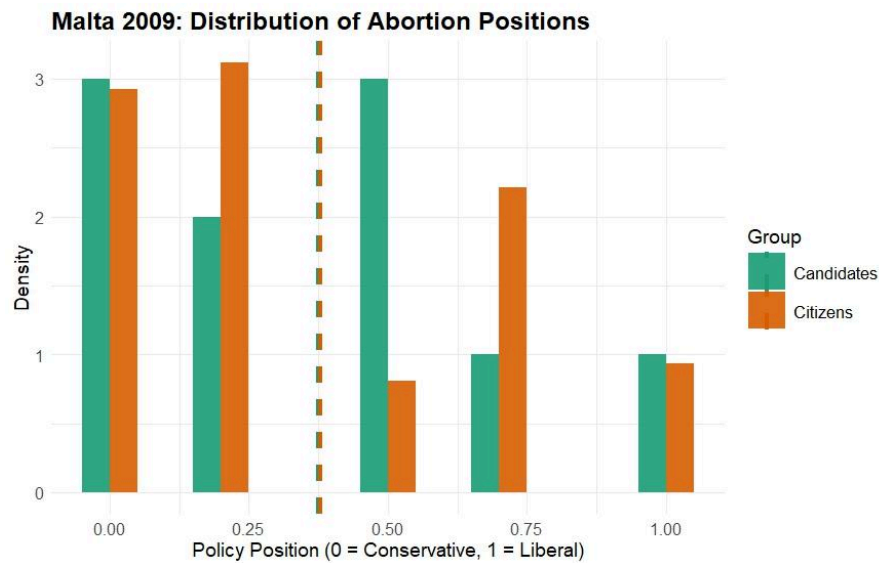
Mean policy positions of candidates and citizens.

Issue	Candidates			Citizens		
	Mean	SD	N	Mean	SD	N
Income Redistribution	0.65	0.33	31,449	0.70	0.28	66,048
Immigration (Economy)	0.69	0.27	31,571	0.50	0.25	39,744
European Unification	0.59	0.33	19,165	0.52	0.28	54,324
EU Membership	0.72	0.41	9,588	0.30	0.43	26,320
Immigrant Integration	0.41	0.31	32,253	0.27	0.27	26,465
Government Intervention	0.70	0.30	31,700	0.52	0.32	25,699
Same-sex Rights	0.75	0.36	29,582	0.52	0.37	25,919
Crime Sentencing	0.45	0.30	33,188	0.25	0.27	26,299
Abortion Rights	0.79	0.30	32,155	0.77	0.28	26,342

After measuring policy positions, *congruence* is operationalized using a measure introduced to the research field by Lupu, Selios, and Warner (2017), called *The Earth Mover's Distance* (EMD). At its core, I compare the preferences of many candidates to the preferences of many citizens. In other words, I assess the similarity between candidate and citizen preference *distributions*. Comparing distributions is a statistically complex task that generally involves reducing them to a single number that is supposed to accurately summarize the degree of resemblance (p. 95). The caveat is that a lot of information about the distributions is inevitably lost in the process. To exemplify this drawback, one way of measuring congruence is to simply calculate the difference between the mean policy preferences of groups of respondents (p. 96). Suppose a group of 10 candidates report a policy preference of 0.5 (which indicates “neutral” on my scale). Their group mean is 0.5. Suppose that in the corresponding citizen group of 10 citizens, half report a preference of 0 (strongly conservative) and the other half a preference of 1 (strongly liberal). Their group mean is also 0.5. Ironically, a comparison of mean preferences has mistakenly classified these candidates and citizens as perfectly congruent and also as politically neutral, when in fact they were highly incongruent because the candidates were politically neutral and the citizens were extreme. Figure 4 illustrates this dilemma using an actual case from my dataset in which candidates and citizens have nearly identical mean policy preferences but where distributions differ considerably.

Figure 4

Distribution of candidates' and citizens' policy positions on abortion rights, Malta, 2009.



Comment: The x-axis shows the available alternatives on the policy position space from 0 to 1 for the question of whether women should be free to decide on abortion. The y-axis shows the density of respondents in each category. The vertical dotted lines visualize the near identical means of candidates (0.375) and citizens (0.378). The difference in means is only 0.003. However, as is visible, the distributions are substantially different from each other. For example, since the value 0.75 on the scale indicates “agree”, a much higher density of citizens than candidates agree that women should be free to decide on abortion. The comparison of means fails to capture this incongruence. Meanwhile, the EMD takes this distribution discrepancy into account. In this specific case the EMD is 0.058. As such, the EMD identifies an incongruence roughly 19 times larger than the incongruence found by the means comparison.

As described by Lupu, Selios, and Warner (2017), the EMD addresses the problem with uneven distributions by incorporating all within-distribution variation and therefore more accurately captures respondents' true preferences and alignment. Put simply, it does this by making comparisons between distributions in which the minimum amount of redistribution required to create identical distributions is computed (p. 96). Because the EMD is essentially a measure of distance (p. 97), the larger the score the less similar candidate and citizen distributions are, and the greater the incongruence between them is (p. 101). My EMD scores are estimated using the so-called “*Manhattan distance*” (L_1 norm) (p. 102), which means that they are measured and expressed on the same 0 to 1 scale as my candidates' and citizens' political preferences.

3.5 Analytical strategy

To maximize the number of comparable units, comparisons in this analysis are made at the country-year-issue level. I start out by matching candidates' and citizens' policy preferences by country and by year to ensure comparability. I also increase statistical power by using ± 1 year matching. That is, in the absence of an exact year match between candidate and citizen survey responses, I use citizen responses from either the preceding or the following year. I then separate the policy preferences of candidates and citizens by country, year and by issue. For each of these country-year-issue units, I subdivide candidates and citizens into subgroups (see subsection 3.4) so that their individual preferences together form preference distributions for each subgroup of candidates and citizens. I then apply the EMD algorithm to these distributions to compute EMD congruence estimates between subgroups of candidates and citizens. To answer the research question "When and why do politicians become less representative of working-class citizens?", the analysis consists of five main parts. It begins by establishing the baseline level of unequal representation, before evaluating the four explanations for unequal representation outlined in subsection 2.3. All evaluations are made by comparing levels of unequal representation in terms of congruence between different subgroups of candidates and citizens. The five parts of the analysis are:

First, to establish a reference point for the rest of the analysis, I begin by estimating the baseline level of unequal policy representation. I do this by comparing *winners'* congruence with *low-educated citizens* to their congruence with *highly educated citizens*. This illustrates the extent to which elected representatives represent working-class citizens less well than middle- and upper-class citizens.

Second, I evaluate Explanation 1, that is, whether unequal representation is driven by the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives. This is done by simulating a counterfactual scenario in which the education shares of *winners* match those of citizens, and by comparing the level of unequal representation exhibited by these "*counterfactual winners*" to that exhibited by the actual *winners*. This demonstrates whether unequal representation would be reduced if there were perfect descriptive representation.

Third, I assess Explanation 2, namely, whether unequal representation is due to working-class representatives not representing working-class citizens substantively. Here, I compare the level of unequal representation displayed by *low-educated winners*, with that displayed by

highly educated winners. Since education level is my proxy for social class, breaking down representatives in this manner shows whether unequal representation persists even among working-class representatives and, as such, whether they represent “their” social class substantively.

Fourth, I evaluate Explanation 3, that is, whether working-class representatives gradually represent the working class substantively less well over time in office. I do this by comparing the level of unequal representation demonstrated by *low-educated rookies* with that demonstrated by *low-educated veterans*. This illustrates whether unequal representation is greater among experienced than inexperienced working-class representatives.

Fifth, I assess Explanation 4, namely, whether the candidates who represent the working class substantively are screened out of the electoral process. This is done by comparing the level of unequal representation exhibited by *winners* to that exhibited by *losers*, which shows whether candidates who fail to win office represent citizens more equally than incumbents.

3.6 Robustness checks

Unlike the majority of my data, which covers national elections, some of the data I analyze is from surveys conducted in relation to European Parliament elections. As discussed (see subsection 3.3), this should not have any meaningful effect on unequal representation. Even so, it is reasonable to test whether the results are driven by this data alone. Therefore, I include a dummy variable to test how my results are affected when the EECS and EES data is excluded from the analytical sample.

3.7 Limitations

Unfortunately, I will largely not be able to compare EMD distances across candidate subgroups. To exemplify what I mean by this, suppose the EMD distance between losers and low-educated citizens is 0.15, while the corresponding EMD for rookies is 0.20, I cannot take this to mean that losers are 0.05 more aligned with low-educated citizens than rookies are. This is because, as illustrated in Figure 1 (see subsection 3.4), the sample size for losers is very large relative to that of rookies. In smaller samples, distributions are generally more “jagged” than in larger samples. The EMD algorithm interprets this “jaggedness” as implying that there is more redistribution needed. Therefore, the algorithm inflates EMD distances

computed from smaller samples relative to those calculated from larger samples. However, this is not an issue when comparing EMD gaps. When I compute an EMD gap between low- and highly educated citizens, the same sample of candidates are used to calculate the distance to both citizen groups. The algorithm therefore inflates both EMD distances equally, which means the inflation technically cancels itself out, making the gap comparable to any other gap. Only being able to compare gaps is a limitation because it restricts me from directly comparing candidate subgroups by their raw alignment with citizens. I am limited to strictly comparing them by the extent to which they represent citizens unequally. Comparing raw alignment would have enabled me to determine, for example, whether one candidate subgroup represents citizens more unequally because it is more aligned with highly educated citizens, or less aligned with low-educated citizens, relative to another subgroup.

Another limitation is that I cannot make causal claims, which limits the internal validity of my study. This is due to the fact that I analyze cross-sectional data, which only allows me to identify descriptive patterns. Consequently, suppose, for example, that I observe that losers represent citizens more equally than winners, I cannot prove that this is actually due to the underlying mechanism that those who substantively represent the working class are screened out of the electoral process. It may instead be due to some other unknown factor. As such, the results of the analysis should be understood merely as descriptive observations that encircle which explanations likely contribute most to unequal representation, to guide follow-up research aiming at testing causality.

Finally, as already mentioned in subsection 3.4, many observations were listwise deleted during data cleaning because of missing data in key variables. This means that there could be selective non-response in the analytical sample. In addition, although I match candidates' and citizens' preferences using ± 1 year matching, it is still not possible to find matches for many country-year-issues, meaning that further observations are excluded. As such, there is also a risk of non-random data exclusion in the analytical sample. Together, these two forms of non-random exclusion of observations raise the possibility that the analysis suffers from selection bias, which possibly threatens its external validity. However, the reliability of my study is strengthened by the use of data from highly regarded cross-national surveys, arguably the most robust measure of congruence that accounts for maximum detail, and a systematic approach to data handling (see Appendix A).

3.8 Ethical considerations

The survey data used in my analysis is fully anonymized, meaning respondents' identities remain confidential. In addition, there is no focus on individual respondents as I only conduct the analysis on aggregated group-level data. Furthermore, I want to highlight that I merely use labels like “low” and “low-educated” as a proxy for working-class respondents. My intention in using these terms is by no means to frame working-class candidates or citizens as lesser or ignorant, or to in any other way pass judgement on them or their preferences.

4. Results

4.1 Baseline unequal representation

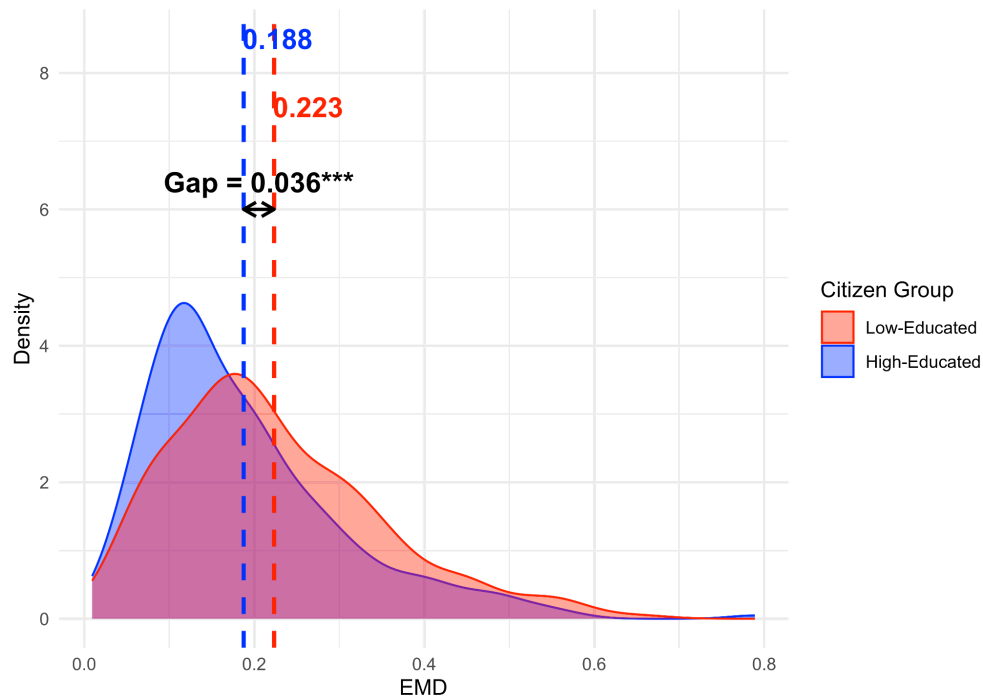
I begin by assessing the extent to which elected representatives represent working-class citizens less well than middle- and upper class citizens. I do this by comparing *winners'* congruence with *low-educated citizens* to their congruence with *highly educated citizens*. To enable this comparison, I start by calculating winners' EMD distance to both low- and highly educated citizens for every country-year-issue. Then, I average these distances across all country-year-issues into two means. One reflects the overall distance between winners and low-educated citizens, the other reflects that between winners and highly educated citizens. The size of the gap between these means indicates the extent to which winners represent citizens equally. The smaller the gap, the more equal representation is. To test the gap for statistical significance, I conduct a paired OLS regression with standard errors clustered by country. If a statistically significant gap is identified, in which low-educated citizens are more distant from winners than highly educated citizens, this suggests that incumbents represent working-class citizens less well than middle- and upper-class citizens.

Figure 5 displays the results from this introductory part of the analysis. It visualizes the distributions of winners' country-year-issue EMD distances to low- and highly educated citizens, including the gap between the means of these distributions. Visibly, winners are more congruent with highly educated citizens (mean EMD of 0.188) than low-educated citizens (mean EMD of 0.223). There is an EMD gap of 0.036 between the citizen groups, which means that winners are roughly 19% more distant from low-educated citizens than from highly educated citizens. Since this gap is highly statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), the

null hypothesis that no inequality gap in representation exists can be rejected. As presented in Appendix F, this gap is robust and, in fact, becomes even larger when the EP-level (EECS and EES) data is excluded from the analysis. Thus, I find evidence of unequal representation in my data, replicating the conclusions of existing studies (e.g. Lupu & Warner, 2022a).

Figure 5

Representation gap between winners and low- and highly educated citizens.

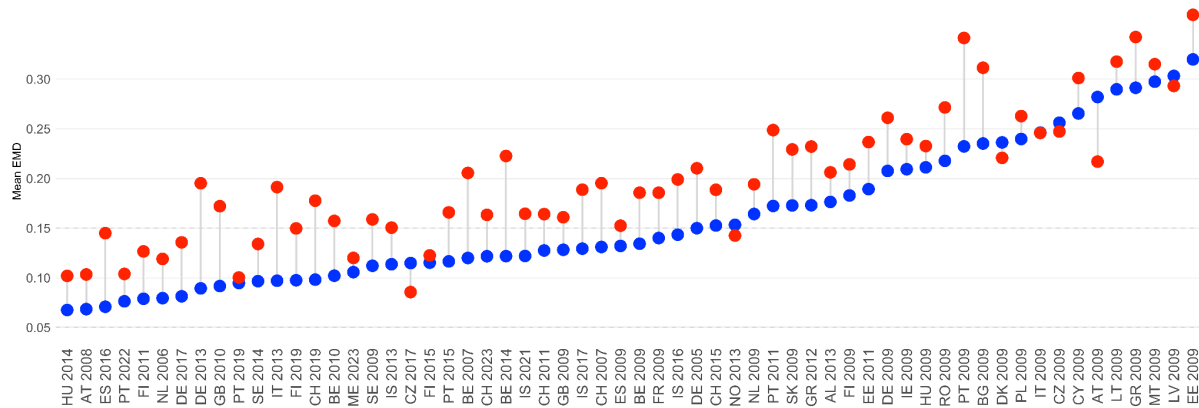


Comment: The x-axis represents EMD distances, and the y-axis shows the density of these distances across country-year-issues. The blue curve visualizes the distribution of distances between winners and highly educated citizens, and the red curve illustrates the distribution of distances for low-educated citizens. The blue dashed line pinpoints the mean EMD for highly educated citizens. And the red line specifies that for low-educated citizens. The gap is tested for statistical significance using a paired OLS regression with standard errors clustered by country.

Notably, the distribution for low-educated citizens looks slightly less concentrated than that of highly educated citizens. This suggests that while the gap in representation is highly significant on average, there is some variance in incumbents' representation of low-educated citizens across the country-year-issues. Figure 6 illustrates the mean EMD distances between winners and low- and highly educated citizens for each country-year in the analytical sample. Clearly, winners are more aligned with highly educated citizens in the vast majority of geographic and temporal contexts included in the sample.

Figure 6

Mean EMDs between election winners and low- and highly educated citizens across country-years.



Comment: The x-axis displays all country-years in the sample. The y-axis shows mean EMDs between winners and highly educated citizens (blue dots) and low-educated citizens (red dots).

Furthermore, Table 2 reports the mean EMD distances and gaps between winners and low- and highly educated citizens across the issues in the analytical sample.

Table 2

Mean EMDs and gaps across issues.

Issue	High-Educ. Citizens	Low-Educ. Citizens	EMD Gap
Income Redistribution	0.139	0.170	0.031***
Immigration (Economy)	0.140	0.217	0.077***
European Unification	0.171	0.198	0.027**
EU Membership	0.217	0.303	0.085***
Immigrant Integration	0.161	0.179	0.018
Government Intervention	0.234	0.253	0.018
Same-sex Rights	0.258	0.275	0.017
Crime Sentencing	0.257	0.294	0.037***
Abortion Rights	0.204	0.213	0.009

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Comment: The gaps are tested for statistical significance using paired OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by country.

Although winners appear more distant from low-educated citizens across the board, the EMD gaps are only statistically significant for 5 out of 9 issues included in the sample. It is insignificant on the issues of immigrant integration, government intervention, same-sex rights, and abortion rights. It is strongly statistically significant ($p < 0.01$) on the question of whether European unification should be pushed further (0.027). And it is very strongly

statistically significant ($p < 0.001$) on the issues of income redistribution (0.031), and crime sentencing (0.037). Interestingly, the largest statistically significant gaps are on the issues of EU membership (0.085), and on whether immigration is good for the economy (0.077). The gaps on these issues are more than twice the size of the other gaps. This indicates that the unequal representation observed in Figure 5 may be primarily driven by socio-cultural (or GAL-TAN) issues, as opposed to economic issues such as redistribution, or traditionally moral issues such as same-sex rights (see also Hakhverdian, 2015). Assuming winners' policy positions reflect those of the broader candidate pool displayed in Table 1 (see subsection 3.4), comparing Table 2 to Table 1 reveals that on the (socio-cultural) issues that drive unequal representation the most, representatives hold far more liberal positions than citizens. The direction of the class bias therefore aligns well with previous research demonstrating that representatives oversupply cosmopolitan socio-cultural policy counter to citizens' (and especially working-class citizens') preferences (see Schakel, Persson & Sundell, 2025, pp. 949-951).

4.2 Evaluating Explanation 1: The descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives

Having established the baseline level of unequal representation, I now move on to evaluating the four explanations for unequal representation that were outlined in subsection 2.3. First, I evaluate whether it is plausible that there is unequal representation because of the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives in parliament. To do this, I simulate a counterfactual scenario in which incumbent education level shares match those of citizens. Technically speaking, I first calculate the proportion of low-educated citizens in each country-year. Next, I attach education-share-based statistical weights to all *winners* in the analytical sample. Highly educated winners are assigned less weight and low-educated winners are assigned more, so that the collective influence of low-educated winners matches that of the share of low-educated citizens. I then replicate the approach used to calculate the actual winners' congruence with low- and highly educated citizens (as described in subsection 4.1) instead using this counterfactual sample of education-share-weighted winners. Since level of education is my proxy for social class, this approach yields counterfactual EMDs and a representational gap that reflects what unequal representation would look like if parliaments descriptively resembled the population by social class. Finally,

I compare this counterfactual gap to the actual level of unequal representation (as reported in Figure 5) to see if perfect descriptive representation reduces unequal policy representation.

Table 3 reports mean EMDs and gaps between the actual *winners* and *low-* and *highly educated citizens*, and compares them with those of the *counterfactual winners* weighted by education level shares. As shown in the second row in Table 3, even if parliaments descriptively mirror citizens by level of education, winners are still more congruent with highly educated citizens (mean EMD of 0.210) than low-educated citizens (mean EMD of 0.241). This means that, relative to their congruence with highly educated citizens, the weighted winners are roughly 15% less congruent with low-educated citizens, which is reflected in the EMD gap of 0.032. Since this gap is highly statistically significant ($p < 0.001$), the null hypothesis that no gap exists can be rejected. Unequal policy representation is prevalent even in a counterfactual scenario of perfect descriptive representation.

Table 3

Actual winners' vs. counterfactual winners' congruence with low- and highly educated citizens.

Candidate Subgroup	N	High-Educ. Citizens	Low-Educ. Citizens	EMD Gap
Winners	280	0.189	0.225	0.036***
Winners (weighted)	280	0.210	0.241	0.032***

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Comment: The gaps are tested for statistical significance using paired OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by country.

Furthermore, since both the actual winners' and the weighted winners' EMD distances are calculated using the same candidates, it is possible to compare these groups' EMD distances. As visible in the second row of Table 3, the mean EMD distances for weighted winners are larger for both low- and highly educated citizens than those of the actual winners in the first row. This indicates that increasing descriptive representation actually worsens the representation of both low- and highly educated citizens. However, although the EMD gap persists for the weighted winners (0.032), it shrinks by approximately 11% relative to the actual winners' EMD gap (0.036). However, this is not because low-educated citizens are represented better by the weighted winners, but because highly educated citizens are represented much worse by them. The weighted winners are 0.021 more distant from highly educated citizens than the actual winners, while they are only 0.016 more distant from low-educated citizens than the actual winners are. This means that the reduction in the EMD gap between actual and weighted winners is primarily attributable to a decline in

representation of highly educated citizens. Taken together, the results in this subsection indicate that descriptive representation slightly reduces the gap in representation. In other words, the results suggest that unequal descriptive representation, at most, slightly drives unequal substantive representation and do largely not support the explanation that working-class citizens are less well represented because there are too few working-class representatives in parliament.

4.3 Evaluating Explanation 2: Working-class representatives do not represent working-class citizens substantively

Having found little support for that descriptive representation drives unequal policy representation, I move on to examining whether unequal representation is likely driven by working-class representatives not representing working-class citizens substantively. Given the results in subsection 4.2, it is already possible to infer that this is arguably the case, since increasing the parliamentary weight of low-educated representatives only slightly reduces overall unequal representation, suggesting that they also exhibit inequality in their representation of citizens. However, to be able to assign relative importance to this explanation, it is necessary to quantify precisely how much of overall unequal representation is attributable to working-class representatives. To do this, I compare the congruence gap between *low-educated winners* and *low-* and *highly educated citizens*, with that between *highly educated winners* and *low-* and *highly educated citizens*. In practice, I replicate the approach used to calculate the winners' congruence with low- and highly educated citizens (as described in subsection 4.1), but instead use a sample in which winners are subdivided by education into low- and highly educated winners. As such, I yield EMD gaps for both low- and highly educated winners, which I then compare. This comparison will indicate whether working-class representatives do not substantively represent their own social class. Table 4 reports mean EMDs and gaps between winners and citizens by education level.

Table 4

Mean EMDs and gaps between election winners by education, and low- and highly educated citizens.

Candidate Subgroup	N	High-Educ. Citizens	Low-Educ. Citizens	EMD Gap
Low-Educ. Winners	150	0.226	0.252	0.026**
High-Educ. Winners	280	0.198	0.238	0.040***

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Comment: The gaps are tested for statistical significance using paired OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by country.

As visible in the first row of Table 4, even among low-educated winners, there is a highly statistically significant ($p < 0.01$) EMD gap of 0.026, in which low-educated citizens are more distant from representatives than highly educated citizens are. Although the EMD gap for low-educated winners is about 35% smaller than that of highly educated winners (as the second row shows a highly educated winner gap of 0.040), this suggests that even working-class representatives represent citizens unequally and represent working-class citizens less well than they represent highly educated citizens. Consequently, these results support, at least in part, the explanation that unequal representation is driven by the fact that working-class representatives do not substantively represent their own social class. However, this cannot be the full explanation. As the gap for highly educated winners is about 1.5 times larger than that of low-educated winners, middle- and upper-class representatives clearly drive unequal representation more strongly. Just as an illustrative example, based on the candidate education shares visualized in Figure 2 (see subsection 3.4), suppose that 30% of winners are low-educated and 70% are highly educated. This would mean that if low-educated candidates, contrary to what Table 3 shows, were in fact fully egalitarian in their representation (i.e. a gap of 0), then the resulting level of unequal representation would be $(0.30 \times 0) + (0.70 \times 0.040) = 0.028$. There would still be a remaining gap of 0.028, completely driven by middle- and upper-class representatives. In other words, they account for roughly 78% of the overall gap. Thus, the search for the full explanation for unequal representation continues.

4.4 Evaluating Explanation 3: Working-class representatives gradually represent working-class citizens less well over time in office

Having found some support for the explanation that unequal representation is due to working-class representatives not representing their own social class substantively, I move on to investigating whether it is also likely that they come to represent the working class less well over time in office. To do this, I compare the congruence gap between *low-educated rookies* and *low- and highly educated citizens* with that between *low-educated veterans* and *low- and highly educated citizens*. In technical terms, I replicate the approach used to calculate the winners' congruence with low- and highly educated citizens (as described in subsection 4.1), but instead use a sample in which winners are first subdivided by education level and then by parliamentary experience into low-educated rookies and veterans. As such, I yield EMD gaps for both low-educated rookies and veterans, which I then compare. This

will illustrate whether unequal representation is greater among working-class representatives with more parliamentary experience than among parliamentary newcomers. Table 5 reports mean EMDs to low- and highly educated citizens for both low-educated rookies and veterans, as well as the gap between these mean distances.

Table 5

Low-educated rookies' and veterans' mean EMD distances and gaps.

Candidate Subgroup	N	High-Educ. Citizens	Low-Educ. Citizens	EMD Gap
Low-Educ. Rookies	114	0.233	0.258	0.025**
Low-Educ. Veterans	116	0.221	0.253	0.032**

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Comment: The gaps are tested for statistical significance using paired OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by country.

Evidently, there are highly statistically significant ($p < 0.01$) EMD gaps for both low-educated rookies (0.025) and low-educated veterans (0.032), in which representatives are more aligned with highly educated citizens than with low-educated citizens. However, the low-educated rookie gap is 0.007 (i.e. approximately 22%) smaller than the low-educated veteran gap. This suggests that working-class representatives who have spent more time in office have about 1.3 times more inequality in their representation of citizens than those who are new to parliament. These results support, at least in part, the explanation that unequal representation is driven by the fact that working-class representatives come to represent the working class less well over time in office. However, as demonstrated in subsection 4.3, working-class representatives account for less of unequal representation, while middle- and upper class representatives contribute even more. To exemplify how much of unequal representation is realistically driven by the fact that working-class representatives spend more time in office, this can be illustrated by calculating a simple counterfactual scenario in which they never become veterans. Suppose again that 30% of winners are low-educated and 70% are highly educated. But suppose that all low-educated winners remain rookies. This means that the low-educated winner gap becomes 0.025 instead of 0.026, while the highly educated winner gap remains the same at 0.040. Then the overall level of unequal representation would be $(0.30 \times 0.025) + (0.70 \times 0.040) \approx 0.0355$. In other words, it would only be about 1.4% smaller than the actual baseline gap of 0.036. Simply put, the results suggest that working-class representatives spending time in office has profoundly limited explanatory power for overall unequal representation, in large part because they are so numerically underrepresented to begin with.

4.5 Evaluating Explanation 4: The candidates who represent the working class substantively are screened out of the electoral process

Finally, I move on to evaluating whether those who substantively represent the working class are screened out of the electoral process. I do this by comparing the congruence gap between *winners* and *low- and highly educated citizens* with that between *losers* and *low- and highly educated citizens*. This will show whether candidates who failed to win office represent citizens more equally than incumbents. To be precise, I again replicate the approach used to calculate the winners' congruence with low- and highly educated citizens (as described in subsection 4.1), and apply the same calculation to *losers*. As such, I yield EMD gaps for both winners and losers, which I then compare. Table 6 presents mean EMDs to low- and highly educated citizens for both winners and losers, as well as the gap between these mean distances.

Table 6

Winners and losers mean EMD distances and gaps.

Candidate Subgroup	N	High-Educ. Citizens	Low-Educ. Citizens	EMD Gap
Winners	286	0.188	0.223	0.036***
Losers	294	0.116	0.159	0.044***

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$. Comment: The gaps are tested for statistical significance using paired OLS regressions with standard errors clustered by country.

As I have already shown in subsection 4.1, there is a very highly statistically significant ($p < 0.001$) EMD gap for winners (0.036) in which representatives are more aligned with highly educated citizens than with low-educated citizens. Interestingly, an even larger gap exists among losers (0.044). As the difference between these gaps is 0.008, this means losers have about 22% more inequality in their representation of citizens than winners. This suggests that those who win political office actually represent citizens more equally than those who fail to take office. In short, these results do not support that unequal representation would be due to the fact that the candidates who substantively represent the working class are screened out of the electoral process. If anything, this comparison rather indicates that many of the candidates who are less equal in their representation of citizens are screened out of the electoral process.

In sum, the results provide no evidence that either explanation drives unequal representation in isolation. Descriptive representation appears to account for a small part of overall unequal representation. Nevertheless, unequal representation does not seem to be primarily

attributable to working-class representatives not substantively representing working-class citizens, nor does it seem to increase notably over the course of their parliamentary tenure. In addition, there are no indications that suggest candidates who substantively represent working-class citizens are screened out of the electoral process. Taken altogether, although working-class representatives exhibit less inequality in their representation than middle- and upper-class representatives, representatives appear to represent citizens unequally regardless of their own social class background or experience in office. However, the main implication of the results is arguably that, given Table 6, unequal representation mainly arises because the pool of those who (can) become candidates is already skewed towards the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens.

5. Conclusions

In recent decades, socioeconomic inequality has grown in many societies, sparking fear (Hager, 2018, pp. 1175-1178) that the affluent may translate their economic resources into political power and use it to advance their preferences, resulting in unequal policy representation that favors them at the expense of less affluent citizens (Hager, 2018, pp. 1192-1193). Therefore, core democratic principles of political equality (Dahl, 1971, p. 1; 1989, pp. 84-85) can be viewed as undermined by such unequal policy representation. Also, as citizens' satisfaction with democracy depends on quality in representation, unequal political influence threatens the social contract on which democracy itself is based (Persson & Sundell, 2024, p. 10).

Given this backdrop, this thesis was devoted to analyzing the roots of unequal policy representation through an evaluation of four possible explanations focused on the identity and supply of candidates for elected office, each of which could account for part of unequal policy representation. The analysis first established baseline unequal representation. Then, it showed that simulating descriptively perfect parliaments only slightly reduced overall unequal representation. Next, it showed that while working-class representatives also represent citizens unequally, they contribute much less to overall unequal representation than middle- and upper-class representatives. Thereafter, the analysis showed that experienced working-class representatives are virtually as egalitarian in their representation as their inexperienced peers. Finally, it showed that candidates who fail to win office exhibit even greater unequal representation than elected representatives.

On the basis of these findings, I conclude, first, that politicians represent working-class citizens less well than middle- and upper class citizens in many European societies. Next, Explanation 1 (the descriptive underrepresentation of working-class representatives) and Explanation 2 (working-class representatives not substantively representing their own class) likely explain, at most, a small part of overall unequal representation. Meanwhile, Explanation 3 (working-class representatives gradually representing their class less well over time in office) and Explanation 4 (candidates substantively representing the working class being screened out of the electoral process) likely explain almost none and none respectively. Therefore, I conclude that politicians contribute to unequal representation regardless of their own social class background or experience in office. Third, I contend that the unequal representation that representatives exhibit mainly arises because the pool of those who (can) become candidates is already skewed towards the preferences of middle- and upper-class citizens.

Based on these conclusions, the answer to the thesis' initial research question, "When and why do politicians become less representative of working-class citizens?", is fairly straightforward: While the exact reason politicians are skewed against the preferences of working-class citizens remains largely unexplained, this thesis has observed that unequal representation exists already in the pool of candidates running for office, which suggests that it may arise before politicians even become candidates.

Previous research has illustrated how candidates are influenced by party gatekeepers (Rehmert, 2022), donors (Gilens, 2012, ch. 8) and particularly active citizens (Broockman & Skovron, 2018). Perhaps candidates need to appeal to such actors very early on in their careers in order to have the opportunity to even become candidates, meaning those who adapt their preferences according to the interests of such groups may become candidates, while those who fail to adapt never do.

That said, these findings and conclusions come with some limitations. As previously discussed (see subsection 3.7), one limitation is the observational nature of this study, which prevents me from making causal claims about any of the four explanations. The conclusions made should thereby not be interpreted as rejecting that any of the four explanations actually could drive unequal representation, or that it in reality may be driven by some other

unobserved factor. As also discussed earlier, another limitation is possible selection bias stemming from non-random data exclusion and selective non-response. However, the fact that the pattern of unequal representation appears consistent across candidate subgroups and country-years, and prevails despite the exclusion of EP-data, provides some reassurance that the results are arguably not a circumstantial product of such bias.

Finally, given the conclusion that unequal policy representation may arise before politicians even become candidates, future policy efforts targeted at reducing unequal representation should focus more on the early stages of candidate recruitment. Furthermore, follow-up research can build on my findings in the following two ways. First, while working-class representatives' presence in legislatures arguably carries important policy implications (Carnes, 2015), and while there is a widespread lack of them in parliaments (Carnes & Lupu, 2015), this study offers additional support to previous arguments that their mere presence would not solve unequal representation (Persson, 2021, p. 5). Nevertheless, since they still contribute to unequal representation, and as it remains poorly understood why they are less representative of their own social class (unlike middle- and upper-class representatives), future research should further examine the underlying reasons for this. Second, future research should investigate why the pool of those who (can) become candidates is already skewed towards the views of middle- and upper-class citizens. Does unequal representation arise during candidacy itself, or is it possible to track it even further back in candidates' careers?

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Appendix

Appendix A: Data processing summary

In total, I recoded data from 15 different raw datasets containing individual-level data: CCS waves 1-3, the EECS 2009 round, ESS waves 2-11, and the EES 2009 round. I recoded each dataset separately before appending them into the final dataset used for the analysis. For each raw dataset, the recoding procedure was largely the following:

1. Drop irrelevant variables.
2. Harmonize descriptive variables like country and year to common format.
3. If a candidate dataset (CCS or EECS), recode respondents by electoral and parliamentary success, as described in Appendix C.
4. Recode respondents' education level as described in Appendix D.
5. Harmonize all policy preference items to a 0-to-1 normalized scale, as described in Appendix E.
6. Generate a variable called “candidateorcitizen” to distinguish between candidates and citizens.
7. Generate a dummy variable called “eucandidate” to distinguish between EU candidates and national candidates
8. Generate a variable called “restype” to distinguish between National candidates, EU candidates, “national citizens” and “EU citizens”.
9. Append with the other recoded datasets.

The final individual-level recoded dataset includes 540,001 observations. All recoding was performed in Stata. But the analysis itself, in which the individual-level candidate and citizen data is aggregated into group-level data, was conducted in R. The R script will be made

available upon request. Unfortunately, I cannot provide any dataset for replication because I have signed data usage agreements that prevent me from doing so. If necessary, I can provide the aggregated group-level dataset upon request. But it will not be possible to use it to replicate the results, because the R script requires access to the individual-level data as well.

Appendix B: Countries and years in the data

Albania	2013				
Austria	2008	2009			
Belgium	2007	2009	2010	2014	
Bulgaria	2009				
Cyprus	2009				
Czech Republic	2009	2017			
Denmark	2009				
Estonia	2009	2011			
Finland	2009	2011	2015	2019	
France	2009				
Germany	2005	2009	2013	2017	
Greece	2009	2012			
Hungary	2009	2014			
Iceland	2013	2016	2017	2021	
Ireland	2009				
Italy	2009	2013			
Latvia	2009				
Lithuania	2009				
Malta	2009				
Montenegro	2023				
Netherlands	2006	2009			
Norway	2013				
Poland	2009				
Portugal	2009	2011	2015	2019	2022
Romania	2009				
Slovakia	2009				
Spain	2009	2016			
Sweden	2009	2014			
Switzerland	2007	2011	2015	2019	2023
United Kingdom	2009	2010			

Appendix C: CCS and EECS survey items used to aggregate candidates by electoral and parliamentary success

Please note that the variable names, question wordings, and coding schemes are based on the official codebooks or questionnaires accompanying each respective dataset.

Survey	Wave	Item name	Question	Original coding
CCS	1	T8	Whether the respondent was elected in the current election [data based on either a question or external sources]	0=Not elected 1=Elected 7=Not applicable 9=No answer or missing -1=Question not asked or data not available [see details below]
CCS	2	T11	Did the candidate get elected	0 = no 1 = yes
CCS	3	T11	Did the candidate get elected	0 = no 1 = yes
CCS	1	A4b1 A4b2 A4b3 A4b4 A4b5 A4b6	Elected in the ->X most recent national election?	1 = yes 2 = no 9 = no answer -1 = Q not asked
CCS	2	A4b1 A4b2 A4b3 A4b4 A4b5 A4b6	Elected in election [year X]	1 = yes 2 = no -2 = not applicable
CCS	3	A4b1 A4b2 A4b3 A4b4	Elected in election [year X]	1 = yes 2 = no -9 = no answer -2 = not applicable -1 = Q not asked
EECS	2009	mep	Was the candidate elected	1 = mep 2 = no mep

EECS	2009	v045_3	Are you / have you ever been a member of a national representative body?	1 = yes, at the moment 2 = yes, in the past 3 = no, never -99 = no valid answer
EECS	2009	v045_4	Are you / have you ever been a member of the EP?	1 = yes, at the moment 2 = yes, in the past 3 = no, never -99 = no valid answer

Recoding strategy:

I created the variable “winnerorloser” to distinguish between candidates based on electoral and parliamentary success. It is coded 1 for losers, 2 for rookies and 3 for veterans (rookies and veterans together constitute winners).

Step 1:

Using the items that indicate whether a candidate won or lost, I recoded any value indicating that they lost the current election to 1 (losers). Then, I recoded any value indicating that they won to 2 (winners).

Step 2:

If any of the items that indicate the candidate has previous parliamentary experience was coded in a way that shows the candidate has previous experience, I recoded winners to 3 (Veterans). If none of those items were coded in a way that suggests the candidate has previous experience, I recoded winners to 2 (Rookies).

Step 3:

All forms of non-answers were recoded to missing.

Appendix D: Survey items used to aggregate respondents by education level

Please note that the variable names, question wordings, and coding schemes are based on the official codebooks or questionnaires accompanying each respective dataset.

Survey	Wave	Item name	Question	Original coding
CCS	1	E6a	Level of education, recoded into seven common categories.	1=incomplete primary 2=primary completed 3=incomplete secondary 4=secondary completed 5=post secondary trade/vocational school 6=university incomplete 7=university completed 9=no answer -1=Q not asked
CCS	2	E6a	Highest level of education	1 = none 2 = incomplete 3 = primary 4 = incomplete 5 = secondary 6 = post-secondary trade/vocational 7 = university degree 8 = university degree completed
CCS	3	E5	Highest level of education	0 = none 1 = early childhood 2 = primary 3 = lower secondary 4 = upper secondary 5 = post-secondary non-tertiary 6 = short-cycle tertiary 7 = Bachelor or equivalent 8 = Master or equivalent 9 = Doctoral or equivalent -9 = no answer -1 = Q not asked

EECS	2009	v056_1	What is the highest level of education you have completed in your education?	[0] Pre-primary or no education [10] Primary [20] Lower secondary (no additional information) [21] Lower secondary (leads to level 3 and ultimately to tertiary education) [22] Lower secondary (leads to level 3) [23] Lower secondary (direct access to labour market) [30] Upper secondary (no additional information) [31] Upper secondary (direct access to 5A) [32] Upper secondary (direct access to 5B) [33] Upper secondary (not designed to lead to tertiary education) [40] Post secondary non-tertiary (no additional information) [41] Post secondary non-tertiary (leads to level 5) [42] Post secondary non-tertiary (direct access to labour market or 5B) [43] Post secondary non-tertiary (direct access to labour market) [51] First stage of tertiary (academic degree) [52] First stage of tertiary (tertiary vocational program) [60] Second stage of tertiary (i.e. doctorate) -99
ESS	Rounds 2-4	edulvla	Highest level of education	0 Not possible to harmonise into 5-level ISCED 1 Less than lower secondary education (ISCED 0-1) 2 Lower secondary education completed (ISCED 2) 3 Upper secondary education completed (ISCED 3) 4 Post-secondary non-tertiary education completed (ISCED 4) 5 Tertiary education completed (ISCED 5-6) 55 Other .a (77) Refusal* .b (88) Don't know* .c (99) No answer* *) Missing Value
ESS	Rounds 5-11	eisced	Highest level of education, ES - ISCED	0 Not possible to harmonise into ES-ISCED 1 ES-ISCED I , less than lower secondary 2 ES-ISCED II, lower secondary 3 ES-ISCED IIIb, lower tier upper secondary 4 ES-ISCED IIIa, upper tier upper secondary 5 ES-ISCED IV, advanced vocational, sub-degree 6 ES-ISCED V1, lower tertiary education, BA level 7 ES-ISCED V2, higher tertiary education, >= MA level 55 Other .a (77) Refusal* .b (88) Don't know* .c (99) No answer* *) Missing value

EES	2009	Q101	What is the highest level of education you have completed in your education?	Each country has unique education codes, which would be redundant to paste here.
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Recoding strategy:

I created the variable “neweducationlevel” to distinguish between respondents based on their level of education. It is coded 1 for low-educated and 2 for highly educated.

Step 1:

For CCS, ESS, and EECs observations, if the original coding indicated a respondent held at least a university bachelor’s degree or above, the respondent was recoded to 2 (highly educated). If the original coding indicated a respondent did not hold at least a bachelor’s degree, the respondent was recoded to 1 (low-educated).

Step 2:

All forms of non-answers were recoded to missing.

Step 3:

I had to recode the EES observations differently and separately because each country had country-specific education level codes. In short, the procedure was the following:

- a) Generate the "neweducationlevel" variable
- b) Recode non-answers to missing
- c) Recode all valid responses in the old q101 variable to 1 (low-educated) in the neweducationlevel variable.
- d) Using the country-specific codes in the old variable indicating respondents hold at least a university bachelor’s degree or above, recode all those observations to 2 (highly educated) in the neweducationlevel variable.
- e) Merge with the other data.

Appendix E: Original survey items included in the analysis

Please note that the variable names, question wordings, and coding schemes are based on the official codebooks or questionnaires accompanying each respective dataset.

Issue	Original survey item (CCS)	Original survey item (EECS)	Original survey item (ESS)	Original survey item (EES)	Question wording example
Income redistribution	C2h	v020_08	gincdif (rounds 2-5) B26 (rounds 6-7) B33 (rounds 8-11)	q63	The government should take measures to reduce differences in income levels
Immigration (Economy)	C2j (wave 1) C2i (waves 2 & 3)	NA	imbgeco (rounds 2-5) B38 (round 6) B32 (round 7) B41 (round 8-9) B43 (rounds 10-11)	NA	Immigrants are good for the country's economy
European Unification	C5 (wave 1 & 2) C7 (wave 3)	v029_1	euftr (rounds 2-4) Round 5 NA B28 (rounds 6-7) B37 (rounds 8-11)	q80	European Unification to be pushed further
EU Membership	C4 (wave 1 & 2) C6 (wave 3)	v024	NA	q79	Country's membership of the European Union a good thing
Immigrant Integration	C2a	v020_01	NA	q56	Immigrants should be required to adapt to the customs of the country
Government Intervention	C2b	v020_06	NA	q61	Governments should abstain from intervening in the economy
Same-sex Rights	C2d	v020_03	NA	q58	Same-sex marriages should be prohibited by law

Crime Sentencing	C2f	v020_07	NA	q62	People who break the law should be given stiffer sentences
Abortion Rights	C2k (wave 1) C2j (waves 2 & 3)	v020_05	NA	q60	Women should be free to decide on matters of abortion

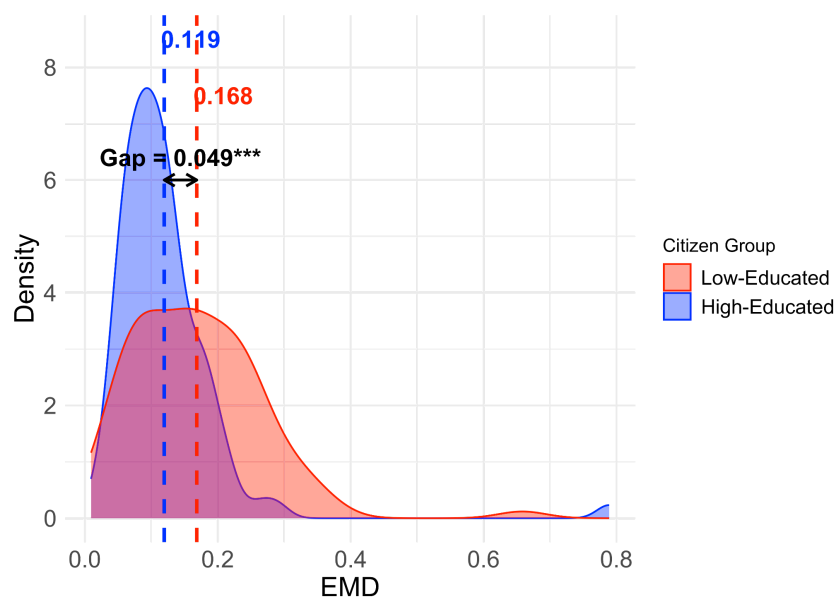
Recoding strategy:

I harmonized the scales of these question items by rescaling the original variables linearly to fit a 0-to-1 scale, on which the value 0 always indicates the most conservative position and 1 always indicates the most liberal position. In some instances, this required reverse-coding the direction of the scales. For example, if one survey item was worded “European unification should be pushed further”, while the corresponding item in another survey was worded “European unification has gone too far”.

Appendix F: Baseline unequal representation excluding EU-level data

Figure 7

Representation gap between winners and low- and highly educated citizens using national level data only.



Comment: The x-axis represents EMD distances, and the y-axis shows the density of these distances across country-year-issues. The blue curve visualizes the distribution of distances between winners and highly educated citizens, and the red curve illustrates the distribution of distances for low-educated citizens. The blue dashed line pinpoints the mean EMD for highly educated citizens. And the red line specifies that for low-educated citizens. The gap is tested for statistical significance using a paired OLS regression with standard errors clustered by country.